and he claimed that he had come on the invitation of S.D. Krishna Aiyangar regarding the steamer.[194] But the primary purpose was ‘to settle brokerage and commission accounts’ with the company.[195] SSNCo owed him Rs 10,000 on this score, and he is said to have demanded payment on pain of filing a suit.[196] But since S.D. Krishna Aiyangar was away in Kakinada and Madras on company business most of the time, he left disappointed.[197] ‘The Tinnevelly directors’ promised to settle his dues before 15 October only the day before his departure. But Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. were far from sure about it.[198]

The SSNCo’s head accountant V. Sankaraiah’s letter of these times has also survived. Despite being in prison, it is evident that VOC was being regularly informed by various sources about the working of SSNCo including its finances. (‘I may be able to prepare & publish our a/c of income & expenditure mentioned in your letter very shortly having collected necessary informations [sic] re: moneys collected with assistance of S.T.A. & others.’[199])

And yet, with no one in the company to resolve the issues, its key vendors—the Agents at Colombo and Bombay—took recourse to venting their frustration with VOC even though he was in fetters. More than moral responsibility it was the trust and goodwill that he had won that runs through the correspondence. Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. said politely, ‘We get little satisfaction from the Company presently, but we have kept up our connection for your friendship only’. As we saw above, the Colombo Agent Thumbayya also sought VOC’s intervention.

These complaints show that the company was not able to meet its commitments. Many of the business agreements—including major ones that pertained to the terms with Agents—had not been committed to paper. Personal relations had undergirded professional ones. Even a seasoned business company as the Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. went so far as to say, in reference to VOC, that ‘we have kept up our connection for your friendship only’.[200] It is difficult not to be moved by the words: ‘When our Mr Damodar was at Tuticorin he had the pleasure of seeing your children